STUDY AID · MATTHEW 18:1-14 · EPISODE 35 OF 58

Humble Like *This Child*



Whoever therefore will humble himself as this child…

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 18:1-14 in the LSB | 23:56 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: The Hidden Threat Inside the Church. Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND (ADDED) · DEBATED · LSB TEXT · ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 18:1-14. The disciples ask who is greatest in the kingdom of heaven. Jesus sets a child before them: unless they are converted and become like children they will never enter it, and whoever humbles himself like this child is the greatest. Whoever causes one of these little ones to stumble would be better drowned with a millstone around his neck. Cut off the hand or foot, tear out the eye, that causes you to stumble. Do not despise the little ones; the Father seeks the one straying sheep.
- This is the fourth of Jesus' five discourses in Matthew, the discourse on church community, after the Sermon on the Mount (5-7), the mission discourse (10) and the parables (13). Five discourses recall the five books of Torah.
- The video traces the disciples' argument back to the temple tax (17:24-27): they heard 'the sons are exempt' as a promise of status, not of God's provision. Mark and Luke tell of the argument (Mark 9:33-34; Luke 9:46).
- Becoming like a child is about being lowly and dependent, not uneducated or naive. Jesus holds people accountable for the faith of others, and the hyperbole of cutting off a hand works like a fence around the Torah that drives the problem back to the heart. The one-sheep picture recalls Ezekiel 34, where God judges shepherds who fed themselves and scattered the flock.
- The lesson: to be a part of God's community, Jesus' disciples must get rid of all forms of pride and self-

> *"In order to be a part of God's community, Jesus' disciples must get rid of all forms of pride and self-seeking.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"Pride is the great temptation that must be cut off.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

seeking, and be tremendously concerned with depending on God and taking care of His sheep.

Read the whole scene together

The teacher reads 18:1-14 as one answer to one bad question. The child, the millstone, the cut-off hand and the lost sheep all respond to 'Who then is greatest?' Read them together and the problem comes into focus: pride.

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB.

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Scripture passages covered

The video reads all of Matthew 18:1-14 and turns to Matthew 17, Mark 9, Luke 9, Matthew 5, 1 Timothy 3 and Ezekiel 34. Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 18:1-14
Read in full: the child, stumbling blocks, and the straying sheep.

Mark 9:33-37
Mark: the argument on the way.

Luke 9:46-48
Luke: the least is the one who is great.

Matthew 17:24-27
The temple tax: 'the sons are exempt.'

Matthew 5:29-30
The eye and the hand, said before.

Matthew 5:5
Blessed are the lowly.

James 3:1
Teachers receive a stricter judgment.

1 Timothy 3:1-7
An overseer's qualities are character traits.

Ezekiel 34:1-24
Woe to the shepherds; one shepherd, My servant David.

Luke 15:3-7
Luke's lost sheep.

Matthew 18:15-35
Coming next: forgiveness in God's community.

Key verses in the LSB

“Truly I say to you, unless you are converted and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven.”

Matthew 18:3 (LSB)

“See that you do not despise one of these little ones, for I say to you that their angels in heaven continually see the face of My Father who is in heaven.”

Matthew 18:10 (LSB)

“In this way, it is not the will of your Father who is in heaven that one of these little ones perish.”

Matthew 18:14 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

Who then is greatest?

A bad question, a real child, and the fourth discourse.



MATTHEW 18:1; 17:26

Who then is greatest?

THE DISCIPLES · MATTHEW 18:1

“At that time the disciples came to Jesus and said, “Who then is greatest in the kingdom of heaven?””

JUST BEFORE · MATTHEW 17:26

“And when Peter said, “From strangers,” Jesus said to him, “Then the sons are exempt.”

FROM THE VIDEO The video thinks the argument grew out of the temple-tax teaching. Jesus meant that God provides for His children; they heard that they now had great status as sons of the King.

FROM THE VIDEO How wrong is that question? Jesus immediately recognized what it revealed: pride.

◆ Factbook: Kingdom of heaven ◆ Factbook: Temple tax (half-shekel)



MATTHEW 18:2-4

A real child in the middle

🧒 MATTHEW 18:2-4 (LSB)

OBJECT LESSON

“And He called a child to Himself and set him before them, and said, “Truly I say to you, unless you are converted and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven. Whoever therefore will humble himself as this child, he is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.”

FROM THE VIDEO Like a good Jewish rabbi, Jesus points to a real child. It is not about being uneducated or naive, but lowly and humble, relying on the heavenly Father for all things as little children rely on their parents.

FROM THE VIDEO Remember the Beatitudes: 'Blessed are the lowly, for they shall inherit the earth' (Matthew 5:5). Matthew 5:5

◆ Factbook: The Beatitudes ◆ Factbook: Rabbi

MARK 9:33-34; LUKE 9:46

On the way

MARK · MARK 9:34

“But they kept silent, for on the way they had discussed with one another which of them was the greatest.”

LUKE · LUKE 9:48

“and said to them, “Whoever receives this child in My name receives Me, and whoever receives Me receives Him who sent Me; for the one who is least among all of you, this is the one who is great.””

FROM THE VIDEO For more details on the argument, the video points to Mark 9:33-34 and Luke 9:46.

BACKGROUND Mark sets the scene in a house in Capernaum (Mark 9:33). Mark 9:33

◆ Factbook: Capernaum ◆ Factbook: Disciples

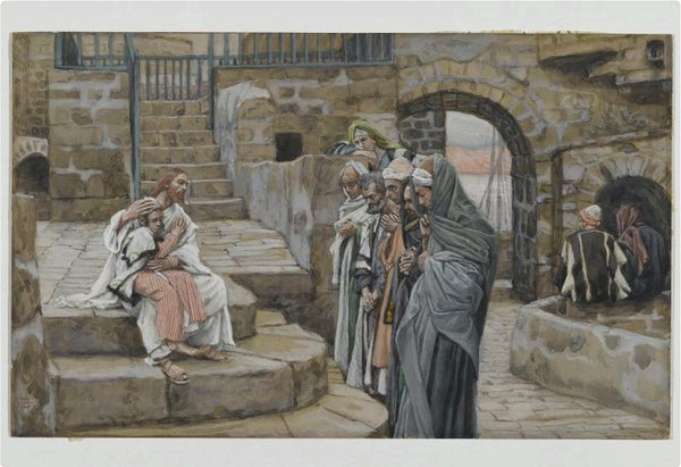
MATTHEW 7:28; 11:1; 13:53; 19:1; 26:1

The fourth discourse

FROM THE VIDEO Matthew gathers Jesus' teaching into five discourses: the Sermon on the Mount (5-7), mission (10), parables (13), church community (18), and a fifth still to come. Every good Jew would have recognized the parallel with the five books of Torah.

BACKGROUND Each discourse closes with the same formula: 'when Jesus had finished these words' (7:28; 19:1; 26:1), 'finished giving instructions' (11:1), 'finished these parables' (13:53). Matthew 7:28 Matthew 19:1 Matthew 26:1

◆ Factbook: Sermon on the Mount ◆ Factbook: Moses



He called a child to Himself

James Tissot, Jesus and the Little Child, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *“It's not about being uneducated or naive. It's about being lowly and humble.*
>
> From the video

04 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

Stumbling blocks

A millstone, a stricter judgment, and what must be cut off.



MATTHEW 18:6

A heavy millstone

MATTHEW 18:6 (LSB)

ACCOUNTABLE

“but whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in Me to stumble, it is better for him that a heavy millstone be hung around his neck, and that he be drowned in the depth of the sea.”

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus holds people accountable for the faith of others. If a pastor's moral failing causes people to fall away, whose fault is that? We cannot answer properly without wrestling with this verse.

BACKGROUND The Greek says a donkey's millstone (mylos onikos), the large upper stone turned by an animal, not a small hand mill.

◆ Factbook: Persecution



JAMES 3:1; 1 TIMOTHY 3:2, 6

A stricter judgment

JAMES · JAMES 3:1

“Do not, many of you, become teachers, my brothers, knowing that we will receive a stricter judgment.”

PAUL · 1 TIMOTHY 3:6

“and not a new convert, so that he will not become conceited and fall into the condemnation of the devil.”

FROM THE VIDEO If you want to be a pastor but lack strong character and self-control, sit down and stay away from leadership until you grow up, however articulate or gifted you are. Paul's qualities for an overseer are all character traits.

FROM THE VIDEO You do not have to be perfect, because nobody is. But leaders will be judged with greater strictness.

◆ Factbook: Paul ◆ Factbook: Judgment



MATTHEW 18:8-9; 5:29-30

Cut it off

MATTHEW 18 · MATTHEW 18:8

““And if your hand or your foot causes you to stumble, cut it off and throw it from you; it is better for you to enter life crippled or lame, than, having two hands or two feet, to be cast into the eternal fire.”

SERMON ON THE MOUNT · MATTHEW 5:30

“And if your right hand makes you stumble, cut it off and throw it from you; for it is better for you to lose one of the parts of your body, than for your whole body to go into hell.”

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus repeats part of His Sermon on the Mount teaching. The hyperbole works like a fence around the Torah: if sin is a place, He sets a fence between His people and it.

FROM THE VIDEO But His fence forces people to deal with what is inside, the heart, where sin starts. So what in the disciples' hearts needs to be cut off? Not their literal hands and feet.

◆ Factbook: Gehenna ◆ Factbook: Sermon on the Mount

MATTHEW 18:7

Pride must be cut off

🔥 MATTHEW 18:7 (LSB)

THE ANSWER

““Woe to the world because of its stumbling blocks! For it is inevitable that stumbling blocks come; nevertheless, woe to that man through whom the stumbling block comes!”

FROM THE VIDEO When the question sinks in, you realize pride is the great temptation that must be cut off and torn out. Otherwise it will lead to despising the little ones (v10), cause them to stumble (v6), and scatter the sheep.

> *“Pride is the great temptation that must be cut off.*
>
> From the video

05 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

The one that is straying

Do not despise the little ones; Ezekiel's shepherds.

MATTHEW 18:10

Do not despise them

👀 MATTHEW 18:10 (LSB)

LOOK DOWN

““See that you do not despise one of these little ones, for I say to you that their angels in heaven continually see the face of My Father who is in heaven.”

FROM THE VIDEO The Greek word for despise means to look down upon and scorn. The picture is of someone who does not think of another's value or worth, actively insults them, and so causes them to fall away from God's community.

BACKGROUND The LSB brackets verse 11, 'For the Son of Man has come to save that which was lost,' which many early manuscripts lack. Matthew 18:11

◆ Factbook: Angel

MATTHEW 18:12-14

One sheep straying

🐑 MATTHEW 18:12-13 (LSB)

SHEPHERD

““What do you think? If any man has one hundred sheep, and one of them has gone astray, does he not leave the ninety-nine on the mountains and go and search for the one that is straying? And if it turns out that he finds it, truly I say to you, he rejoices over it more than over the ninety-nine which have not gone astray.”

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus contrasts despising a person with a shepherd so concerned about losing even one sheep that he leaves the rest to reclaim it.

BACKGROUND Luke tells the same parable to grumbling Pharisees and scribes, about one sinner who repents (Luke 15:3-7).

Luke 15:3-7

◆ Factbook: Shepherd ◆ Factbook: Parable

EZEKIEL 34:2-6

Woe to the shepherds

EZEKIEL · EZEKIEL 34:4

“Those who are sickly you have not strengthened, and the diseased you have not healed, and the broken you have not bound up, and the scattered you have not brought back, nor have you searched for the lost; but with strength and with severity you have dominated them.”

EZEKIEL · EZEKIEL 34:6

“My flock wandered through all the mountains and on every high hill; My flock was scattered over all the surface of the earth, and there was no one to seek or search for them.”

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus does not quote one passage here; He recalls a theme from the Tanakh: shepherding God's people properly. The clearest echo, the video believes, is Ezekiel 34. Read it side by side with Matthew 18.

FROM THE VIDEO Israel's leaders had become corrupt and failed in their mission, so God's people were scattered and strayed from their purpose to be His ambassadors to the world. 'Scattered. Scattered. Scattered.'

◆ Factbook: Ezekiel (prophet) ◆ Factbook: Tanakh

EZEKIEL 34:11, 23

One shepherd, My servant David

GOD · EZEKIEL 34:11

“For thus says Lord Yahweh, “Behold, I Myself will seek My sheep and care for them.”

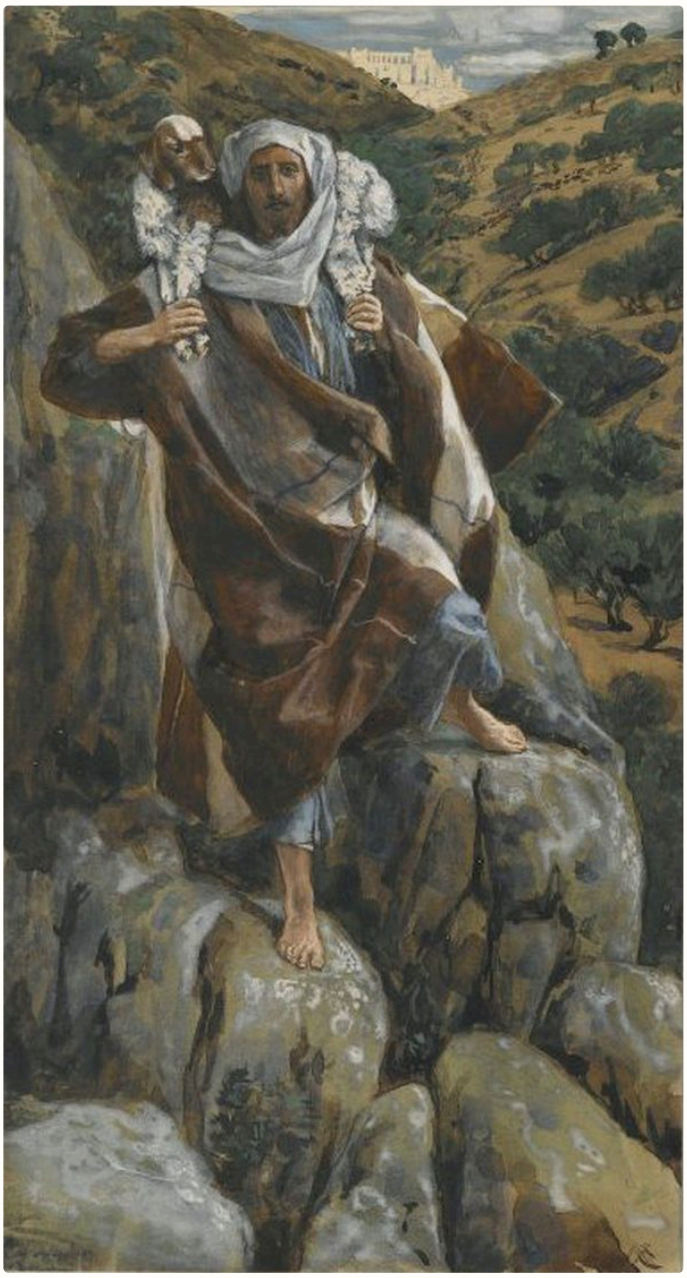
GOD · EZEKIEL 34:23

““Then I will establish over them one shepherd, My servant David, and he will shepherd them; he will shepherd them himself and be their shepherd.”

FROM THE VIDEO The disciples made a mistake, and Jesus brought them back to Ezekiel 34. They are the future leaders of the church; they must not become the shepherds who feed themselves.

BACKGROUND Matthew has already shown Jesus' compassion on crowds 'like sheep without a shepherd' (9:36). Matthew 9:36

◆ Factbook: David ◆ Factbook: Son of David



Go and search for the one that is straying

James Tissot, The Good Shepherd, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *When a person becomes prideful, the quickest, most obvious way to identify this is in their lack of concern for those around them.*
>
> From the video

06

Who's who in 18:1-14

What the video says, then a short background note.

The disciples

VIDEO Argue about greatness; their question reveals pride.

BACKGROUND They will lead the church; Jesus says the great must be servants (20:26).

Matthew 20:26 · ◆ Disciples · ◆ The Twelve

The child

VIDEO A real child, set in the middle as a picture of lowly dependence.

BACKGROUND Mark says Jesus took him in His arms (Mark 9:36).

Mark 9:36

The little ones

VIDEO Believers who can be caused to stumble or be despised.

BACKGROUND Matthew uses 'little ones' of disciples elsewhere too (10:42).

Matthew 10:42

The shepherds of Israel

VIDEO Ezekiel's corrupt leaders who fed themselves and scattered the flock.

BACKGROUND God promises to seek His sheep Himself (Ezekiel 34:11).

Ezekiel 34:11 · ◆ Shepherd · ◆ Ezekiel (prophet)

Ezekiel

VIDEO The prophet whose chapter 34 Jesus recalls.

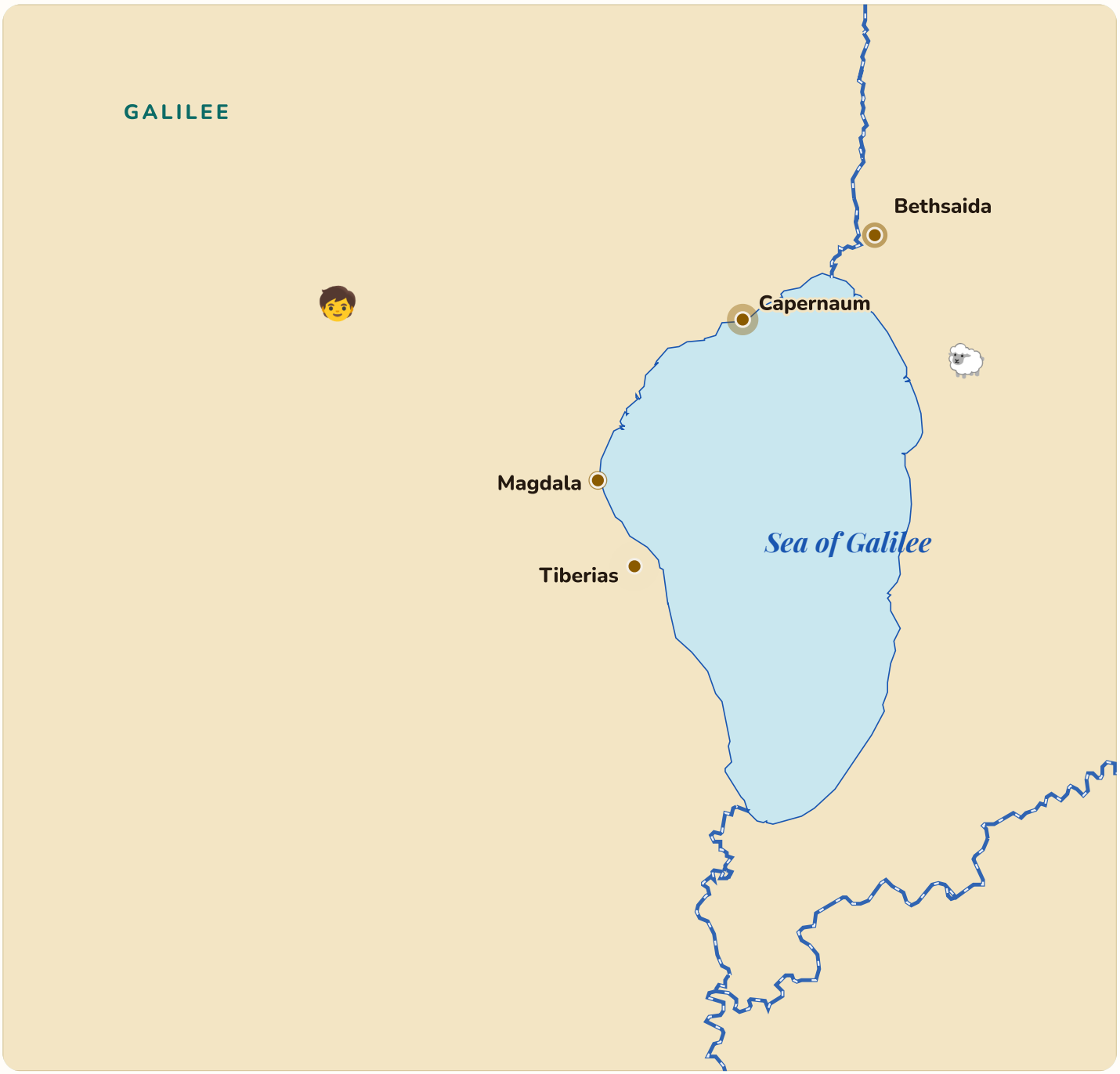
BACKGROUND A priest among the exiles in Babylon (Ezekiel 1:3).

Ezekiel 1:3 · ◆ Ezekiel (prophet)

07 · BACKGROUND

In the house at Capernaum

Gold pins are background places; Matthew names no place here, and Mark sets the scene in Capernaum.



● Named in the video ● Background

Positions from known sites; Bethsaida's exact site is debated. Matthew does not name the place; Mark sets the scene in Capernaum. Lake outline and Jordan River: OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).

Capernaum BACKGROUND

Mark places the argument and the child in a house here (Mark 9:33).

◆ Factbook: Capernaum

Bethsaida BACKGROUND

Peter, Andrew and Philip's town (John 1:44).

◆ Factbook: Bethsaida

Magdala BACKGROUND

A fishing town on the west shore.

◆ Factbook: Magdala

Tiberias BACKGROUND

Herod Antipas' capital on the lake.

◆ Factbook: Tiberias

08

Key terms

Discourse

VIDEO

One of five long blocks of Jesus' teaching in Matthew; chapter 18 is the fourth, on community.

◆ Factbook: Sermon on the Mount

Little ones

VIDEO

Believers who are lowly or vulnerable, not only young children.

◆ Factbook: Disciples

Stumbling block

VIDEO

Greek skandalon: something that trips a person into sin or out of faith.

◆ Factbook: Sinner

Fence around the Torah

VIDEO

Extra boundaries that keep people far from breaking a command (Mishnah Avot 1:1).

◆ Factbook: Mishnah ◆ Factbook: Tradition of the elders

Remez

VIDEO

A hint back to Scripture; here the shepherd theme of Ezekiel 34.

◆ Factbook: Tanakh

Humility

VIDEO

Lowliness and dependence on God, like a child's on a parent. The captions write 'humilies.'

◆ Factbook: The Beatitudes ◆ Factbook: Humility

09 · BACKGROUND

Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

στρέφω

strephō G4762

To turn; here 'be converted,' turn around.

Greek · Matt 18:3

ταπεινόω

tapeinoō G5013

To make low, humble oneself.

Greek · Matt 18:4

◆ Factbook: Humility

παιδίον

paidion G3813

σκανδαλίζω

skandalizō G4624

Little child.
Greek · Matt 18:3, 4, 5

To cause to stumble.
Greek · Matt 18:6, 8, 9

σκάνδαλον

skandalon `G4625`

Stumbling block, trap.
Greek · Matt 18:7

μύλος

mylos `G3458`

Millstone; with onikos, a donkey-turned millstone.
Look up: BDAG, μύλος.
Greek · Matt 18:6

◆ Factbook: Millstone

καταφρονέω

kataphroneō `G2706`

To look down on, despise.
Greek · Matt 18:10

πλανάω

planaō `G4105`

To wander, go astray.
Greek · Matt 18:12

◆ Factbook: Parable of the lost sheep

רָעָה

ra'ah `H7462`

To shepherd, feed a flock; as a noun, shepherd.
Hebrew · Ezek 34:2, 23

◆ Factbook: Shepherd

פּוּץ

puts `H6327`

To scatter. Look up: BDB or HALOT, פוץ.
Hebrew · Ezek 34:5, 6

10

Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED **Facts most interpreters agree on**

A fence around the Torah

The Mishnah opens with the saying of the Men of the Great Assembly: 'Be patient in [the administration of] justice, raise many disciples and make a fence round the Torah' (Mishnah Avot 1:1). The video uses the idea for Jesus' hyperbole: a boundary set far from sin itself.

Children in the ancient world

Children had little status. Jesus does not praise children for innocence, but holds up their lowliness and dependence, and identifies Himself with them: whoever receives one 'receives Me' (18:5).

Shepherds as leaders

In the ancient Near East kings were called shepherds of their people. Ezekiel 34 indicts Israel's kings and

leaders and promises that God Himself, through a coming David, will shepherd His flock.

SOURCED Early witnesses

> *He unveils their conscience, and replies to their feeling, not merely to their words.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 58, on 18:1-3. Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, series 1, vol. 10 (public domain).

> *So exceedingly dear to me is all that is lowly and artless.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 58, on 18:5. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

> *Do you see by how many things He is urging to the care of our mean brethren.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 59, on 18:10-14. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

DEBATED Where scholars differ

Who are the 'little ones'?

Some read young children, others any humble believer, especially new or weak disciples. Verse 6, 'little ones who believe in Me,' points to believers.

Their angels

Verse 10 is a classic text for guardian angels. Others take it more generally: those who serve the little ones stand in God's presence. Chrysostom reads it of angels who have 'fuller confidence' before God.

Why did they argue?

The video links the argument to the temple tax (17:24-27). Mark and Luke place it after the second passion prediction, perhaps a rivalry over Peter, James and John going up the mountain.

CAREFUL READING Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- On the reread, the video says 'greatest in the kingdom of God'; verse 4 says the kingdom of heaven.
- The video reads from another translation. In 18:6 the LSB has 'to stumble' where the video says to sin, and in 5:5 it has 'Blessed are the lowly' where the video says meek.
- Verse 5 is about receiving a child; the warning about causing to stumble begins in verse 6.

- The link between the temple tax and the disciples' argument is the video's suggestion; Matthew says only 'At that time' (18:1).
- The 'fence around the Torah' saying comes from Mishnah Avot 1:1, about the sages' added rules; applying it to Jesus' hyperbole is the video's comparison.
- The captions write 'humilies' for humility, 'biatitudes' for Beatitudes, 'rabbitical' for rabbinical, 'shephering' for shepherding and 'hund' for hundred.

11 · BACKGROUND

From Ezekiel to Chrysostom

Coral dots mark what Matthew 18:1-14 echoes or this episode covers. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

C. 590 BC DEBATED
Ezekiel: woe to the shepherds of Israel
Ezekiel 34:1-24 *Remez: 18:12-14*

C. 200 BC DEBATED
'Make a fence round the Torah' (later recorded in the Mishnah)
Matthew 18:8-9

C. AD 29 DEBATED
The temple tax and 'the sons are exempt'
Matthew 17:24-27

C. AD 29 DEBATED
Who is greatest? The child and the straying sheep
Matthew 18:1-14 *This episode*

C. AD 62 DEBATED
Paul lists the qualities of an overseer
1 Timothy 3:1-7

C. AD 390
Chrysostom: 'dear to me is all that is lowly'
Matthew 18:5

12

Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Mark 9:33-37
The argument on the way
ADDED

Luke 9:46-48
The least is great
ADDED

Ezekiel 34:1-24

John 10:11-16

Woe to the shepherds

ADDED

The good shepherd

ADDED

Matthew 20:25-28

The great must serve

ADDED

Philippians 2:3-8

Humility of mind, the mind of Christ

ADDED

1 Peter 5:2-5

Shepherd the flock; clothe yourselves with humility

ADDED

13

Reflection and discussion

0 of 6 questions marked done on this device.

1 ☐ Why is 'Who then is greatest?' the wrong question?

2 ☐ What does a child's dependence teach you about your own relationship with the Father?

3 ☐ Whose faith could your choices strengthen or weaken this week?

4 ☐ If pride is what must be cut off, what does that look like for you in practice?

5 ☐ Read Ezekiel 34 beside Matthew 18. What does God expect of shepherds?

6 ☐ Who are the 'little ones' around you that are easy to overlook?

14

Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The lesson, stated plainly: in order to be a part of God's community, Jesus' disciples must get rid of all forms of pride and self-seeking. They must be tremendously concerned with depending on God and taking care of His sheep. When a person becomes prideful, the quickest way to see it is their

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

name one 'little one' in your church or family who could be overlooked. This week, do one concrete thing that values them, and pray Psalm 131:1-2 before you do it.

lack of concern for those around them. When God blesses a prideful person's ministry, they use it to glorify themselves and forget the sheep. The kingdom is not a game; it is a mission of partnering with God to put the world back together one soul at a time, and pride is one of the great enemies of His shalom. The teacher asks viewers to work out the lesson in their own circles of influence.

> *"In order to be a part of God's community, Jesus' disciples must get rid of all forms of pride and self-seeking.*
>
> From the video

15

Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ David ◆ Moses ◆ Jordan River ◆ Pharisees ◆ Repentance ◆ Judgment
◆ Galilee ◆ Kingdom of heaven ◆ Satan ◆ Angel ◆ Temple (Jewish) ◆ Capernaum
◆ Book of Psalms ◆ John Chrysostom ◆ Andrew (apostle) ◆ The Beatitudes ◆ Bethsaida ◆ Disciples
◆ Ezekiel (prophet) ◆ Fishing ◆ Gehenna ◆ Herod Antipas ◆ James (son of Zebedee)
◆ John (son of Zebedee) ◆ Law of Moses ◆ Magdala ◆ Mishnah ◆ Tradition of the elders ◆ Persecution
◆ Prayer ◆ Scribe ◆ Sea of Galilee ◆ Sermon on the Mount ◆ Peter (Simon Peter) ◆ Tiberias
◆ Forgiveness ◆ Paul ◆ Priest ◆ Sinner ◆ Son of Man ◆ Tanakh ◆ Babylon ◆ Compassion
◆ Parable ◆ Philip (apostle) ◆ Rabbi ◆ Shepherd ◆ Son of David ◆ Men of the Great Assembly
◆ Church ◆ Temple tax (half-shekel) ◆ Humility ◆ Millstone ◆ Parable of the lost sheep

Source: the video's auto-generated YouTube captions, read in full. Scripture quotations are from the Legacy Standard Bible, copyright 2021 by The Lockman Foundation. All rights reserved. Chrysostom: Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (public domain). Mishnah Avot: Sefaria, Mishnah Yomit by Dr. Joshua Kulp (CC BY). Images: Wikimedia Commons (James Tissot, Brooklyn Museum; public domain). Map data: OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).